

82

Obadiah, Ahab's steward

A quiet believer in a wicked court who hid a hundred prophets under the queen's nose.

Obadiah ran King Ahab's royal household, one of the highest offices in Israel, in a court where Jezebel was killing the LORD's prophets. Yet he "feared the LORD greatly." While the queen hunted the prophets, Obadiah hid a hundred of them in caves and fed them through a famine. Meeting Elijah, he is glad, afraid and a little defensive at once. He did not resign in protest, but he did not bow to Baal either.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Obadyahu</i> , "servant of the LORD"
Position	The "governor of his house," Ahab's palace steward (1 Kings 18:3)
Faith	"Feared the LORD greatly," from his youth (1 Kings 18:3, 12)
When	Ahab's reign, during the drought, c. 860s BC
Key people	Ahab, Jezebel, Elijah, the hundred prophets
Not the same as	The prophet Obadiah, most scholars think
New Testament	Not named

"For it was so, when Jezebel cut off the prophets of the LORD, that Obadiah took an hundred prophets, and hid them by fifty in a cave, and fed them with bread and water."

1 Kings 18:4, KJV

The life of Obadiah, Ahab's steward

Dates are approximate. The drought falls in Ahab's reign (c. 874–853 BC), probably in the 860s BC. Kings gives no exact year.

Ahab's reign	● Serves at court Obadiah is governor over King Ahab's house, a senior royal official. Yet Scripture says he feared the LORD greatly and had done so since he was young. <i>1 Kings 18:3, 12</i>
When Jezebel strikes	● Hides a hundred prophets As Jezebel cuts off the prophets of the LORD, Obadiah takes a hundred of them. He hides them by fifty in a cave and feeds them with bread and water. <i>1 Kings 18:4, 13</i>
Third year of drought	● Searches for grass The famine in Samaria is severe. Ahab and Obadiah divide the land between them and go looking for springs and grass to keep the horses and mules alive. <i>1 Kings 18:1–6</i>
On the road	● Meets Elijah Elijah suddenly stands before him. Obadiah recognizes him, falls on his face, and is told to go and tell Ahab, "Behold, Elijah is here." <i>1 Kings 18:7–8</i>
The same hour	● Pleads his fear Obadiah fears that the Spirit will carry Elijah away and Ahab will kill the messenger. He reminds Elijah how he saved the prophets. Elijah swears to appear before Ahab that day. <i>1 Kings 18:9–15</i>
That day	● Brings Ahab Obadiah goes to Ahab and tells him, and Ahab goes to meet Elijah. The meeting leads straight to the contest on Mount Carmel. <i>1 Kings 18:16–20</i>

Key activities

Scripture never says whether Ahab or Jezebel knew of Obadiah's faith. The text simply sets his fear of God beside his high office and lets both stand.

-
- 1 Feared God in a hostile court.** He served a king who worshipped Baal, yet he kept faith with the LORD. *1 Kings 18:3*
 - 2 Hid a hundred prophets.** At great personal risk, he hid them in caves while Jezebel was killing the LORD's prophets. *1 Kings 18:4*
 - 3 Fed them through a famine.** He kept them supplied with bread and water when food and water were scarce. *1 Kings 18:4, 13*
 - 4 Did his job faithfully.** He went out on the king's errand to search for grass and water. *1 Kings 18:5-6*
 - 5 Honoured the prophet.** When he met Elijah, he fell on his face and called him "my lord Elijah." *1 Kings 18:7*
 - 6 Spoke his fear honestly.** He told Elijah plainly that the errand could cost him his life. *1 Kings 18:9-14*
 - 7 Carried the message.** Once Elijah promised to appear, Obadiah went and told Ahab. *1 Kings 18:15-16*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names this Obadiah.

Old Testament

1 Kings 18:1-16	This is the only account of his life.
1 Kings 19:18	God tells Elijah that seven thousand in Israel have not bowed to Baal. Elijah felt alone, but Obadiah and the prophets he hid show that he never was.
Echo: Genesis 41:40	Joseph ran Pharaoh's house
Echo: Daniel 6	Daniel served pagan kings without bowing

New Testament

Echo: Hebrews 11:38	God's people "in dens and caves of the earth"
Echo: Philippians 4:22	Believers "of Caesar's household"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How did Obadiah describe himself and his past to Elijah (1 Kings 18:12-13)?
2. *Understand:* Obadiah served Ahab and also protected God's prophets. Was he compromising or being wise? What in the text helps you decide?
3. *Apply:* Obadiah worked inside a system run by people who opposed God. Where do you live or work under leaders who do not share your faith? What does faithfulness look like there?
4. *Apply:* Obadiah's courage was quiet and practical: bread and water, day after day. Who needs quiet, practical help from you this week?